Team 17: Daisy Zhong, Anvitha Kosuri, Lexuan Huang

Agentic Interaction

W26

Questions we asked them..

Do you use AI? How often do you use it and what do you use it for?

How should an AI make its internal reasoning or decision-making visible to you while you are working with it?

How would you want to shape or steer an AI agent's behavior over time (e.g., through correction, demonstration, constraints, or ongoing collaboration) rather than just responding to its outputs?

If an AI agent had to share responsibility with a human, how should it decide when to take initiative and when to step back?

Beyond chat, what forms of interaction (e.g., voice, gesture, sketching, physical movement, shared artifacts) would feel most natural or powerful when working with an AI agent—and why?

How should an AI agent show uncertainty or hesitation in its actions, not just in words, so people know when it might be wrong?

How do you feel about AI currently, negative, positive, and why? How do you feel about the direction AI is heading overall in the future and do you think it will create more benefits or more harm in the long run?

As AI agents become more independent and long term, what risks do you see and how can designers make sure users still feel in control?

Meet Our Team

Daisy:
Fourth year computer science major.

Anvitha Kosuri:
Fourth year computer science major.

Lexuan Huang:
Third year computer science major

Who we spoke to, where we interviewed them, and the most extreme user

Person 1: Bob

- Undergraduate CE major at Cal Poly
- Is our extreme user

Person 2: John

- Cognitive Science phD at Wisconsin Madison University
- Is an average user

Person 3: Heather

- 55 year old history teacher at Rocklin high school
- Is our non user

Person 4: Gibby

- 2 year old full time Software Engineer at Appfolio
- Is an average user

Team member roles for each interview

Daisy interviewing Bob

Anvitha Scribed

Lex interviewing John

Daisy scribed

Daisy interviewing Heather

Lex Scribed

Anvitha interviewing Gibby

Anvitha conducted the interview with Gibby while Lex served as the scribe.

Bob:

Why were they chosen/appropriate:

Bob is a passionate computer engineering student so he is very knowledgeable on the topic and was chosen to be our extreme user in AI

Where interviews were conducted

In a coffee shop

How were they recruited

He was visiting Santa Barbara and I asked him to partake in an interview

This was our Extreme User

He was an extreme AI user.

Software used

Ipad for taking notes

Direct Quotes

- “Cal poly provides all students with a free Chat GPT Plus subscription and our professors encourage us to make use of AI tools responsibly”
- “On the whole, I feel pretty negative about the continuation of the current state of AI. I do believe that it will be largely beneficial for humanity, but I still think there are several problems that we need to explore further.”
- “I don’t think users need to feel completely in control if they plan on using agentic AI tool. If a user intends on using an agentic system, then they are inherently giving up some degree of control”
- “I don’t really think that there’s is a great way for the agent itself to indicate uncertainty in its output”

Surprises

He was our extreme AI user, so his take on AI is a bit surprising in the sense that:

1. He feels rather negatively about AI, which is surprising because he is a Computer engineering major that both uses AI a lot and have professors encouraging use of AI. negative about it
2. He doesn’t think that there’s a great way to indicate uncertainty in AI.
3.

Heather:

How were they recruited

Emailed my high school teacher to see if I could interview her

Why were they chosen/appropriate:

She is a history teacher that doesn't use AI. She was chosen because she provides both experience and age diversity to our sample

Software Used

Ipad for taking notes

Where interviews were conducted

On zoom

Direct Quotes

- “I don’t use AI. Not in any direct or intentional way, at least. I’m aware it’s built into tools now, but I don’t seek it out or rely on it for work”
- “I feel skeptical and cautious. I don’t think AI is inherently bad, but I worry that it’s being adopted faster than we’re thinking about its consequences, especially in education”
- “I’m uncomfortable with the idea of having to “train” a system or constantly correct it. If I were to use one, I’d want very clear boundaries from the start, with limited scope and predictable behavior. I would prefer to adapt my teaching to my students, not to a machine.”
- “The biggest risk is loss of human judgment.”
- “I think uncertainty should be built into the design. The AI shouldn’t present information as final or authoritative.”

Surprises

Some surprises were that even though she is quite against AI, she would use consider incorporating it into her life to help execute designs for school projects. She thinks it could be useful as a tool to aid development instead of hinder it. She also believes that it should always take a step back when ethics is involved

John:

Why were they chosen/appropriate:

He is a cognitive science PhD student at Wisconsin Madison. Although he is not directly involved in AI development, he uses AI tools regularly to support his research. He represents a participant who does not work in AI, but still relies on AI in day-to-day academic work. In that sense, he differs from the computer science participant who works directly with AI, and also from the humanities participants who use AI infrequently.

How were they recruited

He came to Los Angeles this weekend to visit his brother, who is an undergraduate at UCLA. I was also in LA and joined them for dinner, so I decided to interview him then.

Software used

Google document file on Mac to note down what was being said.

Where interviews were conducted

In the UCLA Library.

Direct Quotes

"I mostly use AI for general search tasks and work help."

"Right now it feels more harmful than useful because it disrupted the job market and ruined a lot of people's careers."

"Typing feels the most natural, but voice would be nice since you can immediately tell if the message was sent correctly."

"Shared artifacts are probably the most useful because you can give the AI the exact context."

"A neutral mannerism is fine for now, personalization could be a slippery slope ethically."

"The longer the context window, the better. Being able to forget things on command would also be useful."

Surprises

Despite being a frequent AI user, he views AI's overall impact as more negative than positive, especially economically.

He preferred neutral, non-personalized AI behavior, pushing back against adaptive personality as an ethical risk.

He emphasized that AI should promote user growth, not just efficiency, which is an uncommon framing among frequent users.

He accepted over reliance as likely, but still saw human control through frequent check-ins as the best mitigation.

Gibby:

Why were they chosen/appropriate:

Gibby was chosen because he works full time as a software engineer and relies on AI tools every day to do his job. Unlike students, his AI usage takes place in a real professional setting with deadlines, expectations, and long term workflows. He regularly experiments with different AI agents and workflows, which gave us insight into how people actually integrate AI into real work rather than hypothetical use. His experience working at a company that actively encourages agent first development made his perspective especially valuable. He was appropriate for this study because he has personally experienced moments where AI felt helpful as well as moments where it felt uncomfortable or out of control. Talking with him helped us understand how autonomy transparency and trust show up in everyday professional AI use.

Where interviews were conducted

The interview was conducted outside the McConnell's ice cream shop in downtown Santa Barbara.

How were they recruited

The interview was conducted in person in Santa Barbara. The participant was initially met at a networking event in Los Angeles the previous year, where we exchanged LinkedIn contact information due to shared connections to Santa Barbara. Since he works in Santa Barbara and I attend school there, this felt like a natural opportunity to reconnect for the interview. The setting allowed for a comfortable and conversational discussion grounded in real professional experience.

Software used

A piece of paper to write down what was being said.

Direct Quotes

"My company is very pro AI and wants everyone to focus on agent first development."

"We are constantly trying new tools and setups."

"It saves a lot of time and allows people to do a lot more work faster."

"It's constantly proved people wrong on how good it can be."

"Companies are very clearly shoving AI into everything without thinking about it."

"Once the hype dies down there will be a significant pullback."

"I don't think it will result in something catastrophic people will just stop using the product."

"Whiteboards and diagrams are used all the time for software architecture design."

"Voice is not the future."

"Structuring complex ideas into a single uneditable cadence based output is very inefficient."

"I would definitely like more granular control over what tools the AI has access to."

Surprises

Despite being highly experienced with AI tools the participant still felt strong discomfort when agents acted autonomously.

The participant rejected voice interfaces even though they are often framed as the future of AI interaction.

Rather than wanting cautious or hesitant agents the participant preferred systems that could defend their reasoning.

Human like or expressive language reduced trust instead of increasing it.

Correct outputs still felt uncomfortable when the system's process was hidden.

The participant viewed AI hype as temporary rather than dangerous or catastrophic.

Independence was acceptable only when agent actions were visible and reversible.

Visual and spatial interaction such as diagrams felt more powerful than conversational interfaces.

John: a cognitive science phD student at Wisconsin Madison

SAYS

- "I mostly use AI for general search tasks and work help."
- "Right now AI seems more harmful than useful."
- "It disrupted the job market and ruined a lot of people's careers."
- "Typing feels the most natural, but voice would be nice too."
- "Personalized behavior sounds useful, but it's a slippery slope ethically."
- "A neutral mannerism is fine for now."
- "People are already becoming over reliant on AI."
- "The longer the context window, the better."
- "Being able to forget things on command would be useful."
- "Shared artifacts are probably the most useful because you can provide direct context."

THINKS

- AI's economic and social harm currently outweighs its benefits
- AI adoption is moving too fast without enough reflection
- Overreliance is likely and difficult to prevent through design alone
- Designers won't voluntarily limit their own tools' power
- AI should support human growth, not replace thinking
- Transparency matters more than novelty
- Visual explanations of reasoning may help in limited cases, but text is sufficient
- Confidence signaling (ratings, subtle cues) could help users judge reliability
- Most "alternative interaction modes" sound interesting but lack real payoff
- Ethical risks grow as AI becomes more adaptive to individual users

DOES

- Uses AI regularly for search, summaries, and general academic assistance
- Primarily interacts with AI through typed text
- Would use voice interaction occasionally, but not as a default
- Shares documents or artifacts when accuracy matters
- Avoids gesture- or sketch-based interaction
- Evaluates AI output critically rather than accepting it at face value
- Adjusts how much trust to place in AI depending on task sensitivity
- Mentally checks AI outputs instead of fully delegating responsibility
- Treats AI as a tool, not a collaborator with agency

FEELS

- Concerned about AI's impact on jobs, scams, and infrastructure costs
- Uneasy about long-term societal consequences
- Cautiously engaged rather than enthusiastic
- Comfortable with AI as support, not as a decision-maker
- Relieved when AI behavior is neutral and predictable
- Skeptical of hype and "future-facing " interaction designs
- Calm but vigilant rather than fearful
- Calm but vigilant rather than fearful
- Wary of hidden adaptation or behavior shaping

John: a cognitive science phD student at Wisconsin Madison

SAYS

"I mostly use AI for general search tasks and work help."

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"Typing feels the most natural, but voice would be nice too."

"Personalized behavior sounds useful, but it's a slippery slope ethically."

"Bein forget command would be useful."

most useful because you can provide direct context."

Uses AI frequently, but consistently emphasizes the need to stay in control and avoid overdependence.

THINKS

AI's economic and social harm currently outweighs its benefits

AI adoption is moving too fast without enough

Overreliance is likely and difficult to prevent

Designers won't voluntarily limit their own tools' power

AI should support human growth, not replace thinking

Confidence signaling (ratings, subtle cues) could help users judge reliability

but lack real payoff

grow as AI becomes more adaptive to individual users

Believes AI should remain a transparent, efficient tool that supports humans without shaping behavior or decisions.

DOES

Uses AI regularly for search, summaries, and general academic assistance

Shares documents or artifacts when accuracy matters

Avoids gesture- or sketch-based interaction

Evaluates AI output critically rather than accepting it at face value

task sensitivity

responsibility

Treats AI as a tool, not a collaborator with agency

Uses AI selectively and actively monitors its outputs to maintain accuracy and personal agency.

FEELS

Concerned about AI's impact on jobs, scams, and infrastructure costs

Cautiously

Comfortable with AI as rt, not as on-maker

Relieved when AI behavior is neutral and predictable

rather rful

Wary of hidden adaptation or behavior shaping

Feels comfortable with AI assistance, but uneasy when systems act autonomously without visibility.

Key Insights

John

Observation	Inference	Need
1. The participant uses AI regularly for search and work help but avoids relying on it for autonomous decisions.	1.Frequent use does not equate to trust in AI autonomy.	1.Users want AI to support tasks while keeping humans in control.
2. The participant views AI as currently more harmful than useful due to job disruption, scams, and infrastructure strain.	2.Broader societal impacts strongly influence users' trust in AI systems.	2.Users want AI development that accounts for social and economic consequences.
3.The participant prefers typed interaction and finds shared artifacts most effective for accuracy-critical tasks.	3.Utility and context-sharing matter more than novel interaction modes.	3.Users want AI interfaces that prioritize clarity, context, and accuracy.
4.The participant is cautious about personalization and overreliance, emphasizing transparency and user authority.	4.Hidden adaptation and autonomy reduce trust and increase discomfort.	4.Users want transparent, steerable AI that defers to human judgment.

SAYS

"I use AI pretty much every day for my job."

"My company is very pro AI and wants agent first development"

"AI saves a lot of time and lets people do more work faster."

"Claude code felt like I lost control of my computer."

"Structuring ideas into one uneditable flow is inefficient."

"Companies are shoving AI into everything without thinking about it."

"Cursor used to let us tag commits directly."

"I'm generally very positive about AI for coding."

"Voice is not the future for complex ideas."

"That feature was removed because it was buggy."

THINKS

Values efficiency over expressive or human-like AI behavior

Wants AI to behave as a collaborator, not a passive assistant

Prefers editable, visual workflows over linear interactions

Thinks excessive compliance weakens trust in AI intelligence

Wants agents to justify decisions before changing direction

Feels voice interaction is inefficient for complex thinking

Discomfort when agent actions are hidden or opaque

Thinks productivity matters more than novelty

Believes AI is most effective in professional, task-specific contexts

"If I can't see what it's doing, I feel out of control"

"Agents should defend their stance instead of folding immediately"

Believes autonomy must come with transparency

DOES

Uses multiple AI tools daily for coding and design refinement

Experiments with new AI tools and workflows at work

Switches between Cursor, Claude Code, Perplexity, and web based LLMs

Relies on AI to handle large portions of coding tasks

Observes how agents scan repositories and run commands

Evaluates AI tools based on workflow friction

Pays attention to token usage and command efficiency

Manually limits or monitors tool usage when possible

Stops using features that feel buggy or opaque

Notices when agents execute tools without explicit permission

Adjusts context instructions to influence agent behavior

Mentally tracks what changes AI makes versus what he edits himself

FEELS

Confident using AI in professional settings

Optimistic about AI's long term role in work

Discomfort when losing control over system behavior

Annoyed by overly expressive or "chatty" responses

Distrustful when AI changes behavior too easily

Uneasy when AI operates without clear boundaries

Calm about long term risks rather than fearful

Frustrated when agent actions are hidden

Empowered when able to constrain agent tools

Relieved when agents clearly show what they changed

Skeptical of AI hype cycles

Irritated by wasted tokens or inefficiency

SAYS

"I use AI pretty much every day for my job."

"My company is very pro AI and wants

"AI saves a lot of time and lets people do more work faster."

"Claude code felt like I lost control of my computer."

"Structuring ideas into one uneditable flow is inefficient."

"Companies are shoving AI into everything without thinking about it."

"I rely on AI every day at work, but I want to stay in control of what it does."

"Voice is not the future for complex ideas."

because it was buggy."

THINKS

Values efficiency over expressive or human-like AI behavior

Wants AI to behave as a collaborator, not a passive a

Prefers editable, visual workflows

Thinks excessive compliance weakens trust AI gence

Wants agents to justify decisions before changing direction

Feels voice interaction is inefficient for complex thinking

Believes AI agents should be efficient collaborators that remain transparent and steerable.

Believes AI is ost effective in professional, task-specific contexts

"If I can't see what it's doing, I feel out of control"

"Agents sho defend their stance instead of folding immediately"

autonomy must come with transparency

DOES

Uses multiple AI tools daily for coding and design refinement

Actively uses and experiments with multiple AI tools while closely monitoring their actions.

Relies on AI to handle large portions of coding tasks

Observes how agents scan repositorie s and run commands

Evaluates AI tools based on workflow friction

Stops using features that feel buggy or opaque

Notices when agents execute tools without explicit permission

Mentally changes AI makes versus what he edits himself

Adjusts context instructions to influence agent behavior

FEELS

Confident using AI in professional settings

Discomfort

Annoyed by overly expressive or "chatty" responses

Distrustful when AI changes behavior too easily

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Skeptical of AI hype cycles

Irritated by wasted tokens or inefficiency

Key Insights

Observation	Inference	Need
1. The participant described feeling uncomfortable when AI agents scanned files and ran tools without clear visibility.	1.When AI acts autonomously without transparency, users feel they are losing control even if the output is correct.	1.Users want to feel aware and in control while collaborating with AI agents.
2.The participant expressed frustration with AI systems that hide internal reasoning or act silently in the background.	2.Lack of visibility reduces trust and makes it difficult for users to confidently rely on long term AI agents.	2.Users want clear, understandable insight into how and why AI agents make decisions.
3.The participant preferred concise, efficient AI behavior and disliked expressive or overly conversational responses.	3.Professional users prioritize efficiency and task flow over human like interaction styles.	3.Users want AI interactions that are focused, efficient, and aligned with their workflows.
4.The participant actively adjusted instructions and context to regain control over AI behavior.	4.Users attempt to compensate for limited system transparency by manually steering agents.	4.Users want granular ways to steer and constrain AI behavior over time.

Julie: Longtime history educator focused on deep reading and interpretation.

SAYS

- "I don't intentionally use AI in my teaching or planning."
- "Books and archives still matter more than fast digital tools."
- "Students need to learn patience, not constant efficiency."
- "I haven't felt pressure to change what already works."
- "Technology should support learning, not replace effort."
- "Discussion and writing teach thinking better than automation."
- "History requires interpretation, not instant answers."
- "I worry students rely too heavily on shortcuts."
- "AI exists everywhere now, even if I avoid it."
- "I trust methods I've refined over decades."

THINKS

- AI adoption feels rushed, without enough reflection on long-term educational consequences.
- Students already struggle with "deep reading" and AI may worsen that.
- Efficiency is valued more than understanding, which feels dangerous.
- Who controls AI systems matters more than people realize.
- Education should resist trends that weaken critical judgment.
- AI risks becoming an authority instead of a tool.
- Once skills disappear, they rarely return.
- AI may amplify power imbalances already present in institutions.
- Technology often promises progress while quietly removing essential human skills.
- Slowing down learning is sometimes necessary for true understanding.
- Regulation should come before widespread classroom adoption.
- Historical thinking cannot be automated meaningfully.

DOES

- Teaches using discussion, reading, and structured writing assignments.
- Avoids intentionally integrating AI into lesson planning.
- Emphasizes interpretation over factual recall.
- Designs assignments requiring original thought.
- Uses visual tools like timelines and maps selectively.
- Maintains predictable classroom routines.
- Encourages questioning of sources and authority.
- Sets firm boundaries around technology use.
- Prioritizes student dialogue over digital tools.
- Adapts teaching to students, not platforms.
- Limits automation in grading and feedback.
- Preserves traditional learning environments intentionally.

FEELS

- Feels cautious watching technology reshape classrooms without consent.
- Protective of students' ability to think independently.
- Uneasy about "losing human judgment" to automated systems.
- Skeptical of claims that AI always improves learning.
- Frustrated by pressure to adopt unfamiliar tools.
- Anxious about overconfidence in machine outputs.
- Wary of technology intruding on reflection.
- Values calm, quiet thinking spaces.
- Concerned about long term cultural and intellectual consequences.
- Grounded in experience, not novelty.
- Feels cautious rather than safe
- Feels responsible for preserving historical rigor.

Julie: Longtime history educator focused on deep reading and interpretation.

SAYS

"I don't intentionally use AI in my teaching or planning."

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refined over decades."

Prefers traditional teaching methods and openly expresses skepticism toward AI in education.

THINKS

AI adoption feels rushed, without enough reflection on long-term educational consequences.

Students already struggle with "deep reading" and AI may wors

Efficiency is valued more than understanding, which feels

Who controls AI systems matters more than people

Education should resist trends that weaken critical judgment.

AI risks becoming an authority instead of a tool.

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Slowing down learning is sometimes necessary for true understanding.

Regulation sho come before widespread classroom adoption.

thinking cannot be automated meaningfully.

Believes rapid AI adoption threatens deep thinking, human judgment, and ethical interpretation of history.

DOES

Teaches using discussion, reading, and structured writing assignments.

Designs assignments requiring riginal thought.

Uses visual tools like timelines and maps selectively.

Maintains predictable classroom routines.

Prioritizes student dialogue over digital tools.

Adapts teaching to students, not platforms.

Limits a grading and feedback.

Preserves traditional learning environments intentionally.

Teaches deliberately using discussion, reading, and writing while setting firm boundaries around technology.

FEELS

Feels cautious watching technology reshape classrooms without consent.

Uneasy about

Skeptical of claims that AI always improves learning.

Frustrated by pressure to adopt unfamiliar tools.

Anxious about overconfidence in machine outputs.

Concerned bout long term ultural and ntellectual onsequences.

Grounded in experience, not novelty.

Feels cautious rather than safe.

Feels responsible for preserving historical rigor.

Feels cautious and protective, concerned that AI may erode patience, meaning, and student agency.

Key Insights

Observation	Inference	Need
1. The participant stated they do not intentionally use AI and rely on traditional teaching methods.	1.Long established workflows create confidence and reduce perceived need for new technologies.	1.Users need AI tools that respect existing practices and do not force disruptive adoption.
2.The participant expressed concern that AI encourages shortcuts and weakens deep thinking.	2.When tools prioritize speed, educators fear loss of critical engagement and learning depth.	2.Users need AI systems that support reflection and understanding rather than efficiency alone.
3.The participant emphasized discomfort with AI acting autonomously or presenting authoritative outputs.	3. Perceived authority from AI threatens educators' role as interpreters and decision makers.	3. Users need AI that clearly communicates limitations, uncertainty, and non authoritative intent.
4.The participant preferred visual aids like timelines or maps but resisted intrusive interactions.	4. Contextual and visual support aligns with teaching goals, while constant interaction disrupts focus.	4. Users need calm, low intrusion AI interactions that integrate naturally into reflective workflows.

Summary

Key Learnings

It seems that across all users from people that use AI heavily to people who don't use AI at all agree that AI and continuing AI has/will have a negative impact on society. They also all agree that chat form of AI is the preferred way to interact with AI and don't really foresee themselves using other forms in the near future. Most agreed that users shouldn't be able to shape an agent's behavior as it may infringe on an ethical scale allowing AI to possibly manipulate the user, while the extreme user put the responsibility on the user. The non-AI user heavily disagrees and believes there should be guidelines put in for AI.

What’s Next

What’s Next: GR2

Our learnings from GR1 has given us an overview of how different demographics of the general population view AI. From that we can approach GR2 with a better understanding of what we are looking for and can create more questions that allow us to understand more from each demographic and develop compelling POVs. Furthermore, we have gained experience interviewing people which we can continue using for GR2.